behind not just The Ladders and Mithun but Maha Plateau and Lachhman Ridge as well. At the same time, the Chinese were rushing rubber boats to Ashi Hill so that a regiment could be ferried across to attack the Indians on the east bank of the Lohit as well.

Rawlley's instructions to Behl were to aggressively patrol the western flank. On the morning of 3 November, the Sikhs reported some movement in the Green and Yellow Pimple area. Having completed the track from Ashi Hill, the Chinese were in the process of occupying these positions and laying a telephone line that connected them to Ashi Hill.

Ever since 6 Kumaon's Delta Company under Lieutenant Bikram Singh had halted the Chinese advance guard on the Namti Nullah at the base of Ashi Hill, the Indians had the upper hand in the Walong sub-sector. The failure to occupy or even aggressively patrol the high ground above Lachhman Ridge was a tactical blunder. 'We never thought it was possible to get to Green Pimple from the Ashi Hill axis,' said Major Kulwant Singh of 4 Sikh, 'how the Chinese managed to actually get there was amazing. Not having occupied these features was a colossal blunder.'

Two days earlier, Rawlley had ordered another wide recce patrol to set off from the Maha Plateau under the command of Second Lieutenant P. S. Bhandari, who was occupying an observation post of 71 Heavy Mortar Battery. His party, consisting of his own men supplemented by Assam Rifles troops, had camped for the night just below the crest of the West Ridge. The next morning, they skirted past Green Pimple—so named because of the colour of the vegetation that covered it—and spent the night on Yellow Pimple. On 3 November, while dropping down towards Green Pimple, the leading scouts came under heavy automatic fire. Bhandari's party had run into the Chinese who, having occupied Green Pimple, were now moving up to Yellow Pimple. Managing to break contact, the party returned to its base by last light.

The next morning, another patrol was sent out to find out what the Chinese were up to in that area. The 4 Sikh patrol managed to position itself close to the Green Pimple track through which more than a hundred Chinese soldiers passed before they were detected. In the ensuing firefight, both sides took casualties; the patrol had one man killed and seven were wounded. They managed to extricate themselves and fall back on Lachhman Ridge.